cards to 470 diplomats from thirty-two international embassies, 465 staff from six international election observation bodies, 183 staff from nine international organizations assisting in electoral processes, and 9,406 staff of local observation organizations.[6]

Among them, the Carter Center and European Union organized sizeable missions. The Asian Network for Free Elections (ANFREL), a regional network of CSOs focused on election monitoring, was also actively involved. The organization had been working in Myanmar furtively since 1999, and it partners with local CSOs and media organizations to develop talent and support their efforts to deepen civic engagement.

Although international observers and election support agencies generally came to Myanmar with goodwill, they met with mixed responses among local actors. From the perspective of political parties, the critical question was how development partners would distribute their assistance to parties. Some questioned whether international assistance should be accepted at all. For instance, U Sai Leik, spokesperson for the Shan Nationalities League for Democracy, said his party had received no support and was unsure who was benefiting from the international programme. He said, "We have never accepted any assistance from international donors yet" (Ei Ei Toe Lwin and Dinmore 2015). The Rakhine National Party expressed its view that parties should not accept direct international assistance according to the 2008 Constitution. CSOs argued that foreign assistance had little impact at the grassroots level where it was needed, and it could only reach parties or civil society groups with close ties to the UEC.

The general consensus among observers themselves was that the election was fair. For instance, during its press conference, the European Union's election observation mission stressed that the elections was well-run and peaceful (Lambsdorff 2015). The 150 or so European Union observers had reached more than 500 polling stations across the country and reported very positively on the voting process, with ninety-five per cent rating the process as 'good' or 'very good'. However, their assessment was that the process of in-constituency and out-of-constituency advance voting was less well managed and transparent.

In some other settings scholars have pointed to how election observers' reports reveal as much about their own biases as about what has actually taken place in an election (see Kelly 2010). As this was the first time Myanmar allowed international observers in large numbers, it is not possible to make a comparison with earlier experiences and it is also